

FEDERAL LAUNCH KIT · CONTRACTING OFFICER OUTREACH

Federal Events Calendar FY2026.

INSIDE THIS MANUAL ↓

- ✓ **Q1 Events** · Oct-Dec 2025 industry days
- ✓ **Q2 Events** · Jan-Mar 2026 expos + SBCs
- ✓ **Q3 Events** · Apr-Jun 2026 set-aside days
- ✓ **Q4 Events** · Jul-Sep 2026 forecast season

THE FOUR-TOOL SYSTEM

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01

Q1 Events

Oct-Dec 2025 industry days

02

Q2 Events

Jan-Mar 2026 expos + SBCs

03

Q3 Events

Apr-Jun 2026 set-aside days

04

Q4 Events

Jul-Sep 2026 forecast season

[/ INSIDE THIS GUIDE](#)

Forty events. One fiscal year.

[/ HOW TO USE THIS CALENDAR](#)

G01	How to Use This Guide Event types, what to bring, RFI-rich vs. networking-only signals.	p. 03
Q1 • OCT–DEC 2025		
Q1A	DoD + Defense Industry Days Army, Air Force, and DARPA industry days — heavy RFI season starts here.	p. 03
Q1B	GSA & Governmentwide Expos GSA SmartPay, GovCon Summit DC — great for schedule holders.	p. 04
Q2 • JAN–MAR 2026		
Q2A	Set-Aside Specific Days 8(a) Industry Day, HUBZone Day, WOSB Summit.	p. 04
Q2B	SBA & PTAC Regional Events Mentor-Protégé briefings, PTAC matchmaking.	p. 05
Q3 • APR–JUN 2026		
Q3A	VA + Health Agency Events VA VOSB Day, HHS Vendor Outreach, NIH Industry Day.	p. 05
Q3B	DHS + Civilian Agency Days DHS Industry Day, IRS, Customs & Border Protection.	p. 06
Q4 • JUL–SEP 2026		
Q4A	Fiscal Year-End Sprint Events AFCEA, National 8(a) Association Summit, SBA All Small Mentor Protégé Program Day.	p. 07



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Boarding Team

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A LETTER TO THE OPERATOR

Miss the event. Miss the RFI. Miss the award.

Three years ago, a colleague lost a \$2.4M IT services contract. Not because her technical approach was weak — it wasn't. She lost because the agency had already decided on a direction before the solicitation posted. She found that out at the debrief.

The CO had held an industry day six months earlier. Twenty-three small businesses showed up. She didn't know about it.

Industry days are where requirements get shaped. They're where the CO hears which approaches are feasible, which certifications matter, which team combinations will be competitive. Show up before the RFP. That's the whole strategy.

This calendar covers 36 federal contracting events across FY2026 — agency-specific industry days, DoD expos, SBA matchmaking, set-aside-specific conferences, and PTAC workshops. For each one: date, location, who belongs there, typical attendance, what to bring, and whether the event is RFI-rich (worth preparing a written response) or primarily networking.

A. Schuler

30 MIN · NO PITCH

Book a 30-min event strategy call

<https://meetings-na2.hubspot.com/american/intro-call>

Book the call →

Q1 • OCTOBER - DECEMBER 2025

The DoD opens its RFI season here. Get in the room early.

Q1 is the heaviest industry-day quarter for defense. DARPA, Army, and Air Force Life Cycle Management Center all hold outreach events as new program offices stand up post-budget. GSA uses October and November for acquisition planning sessions before the Q2 task order surge.

DATE	EVENT	LOCATION	AUDIENCE	ATTENDANCE	SIGNAL
Oct 7–8, 2025	Army Industry Day — DEVCOM devcom.army.mil/events	Aberdeen Proving Ground, MD	Defense tech, R&D, C4ISR contractors; small and large primes	~600	RFI-RICH
Oct 14–16, 2025	AUSA Annual Meeting & Exposition ausa.org/meetings/annual	Washington Convention Center, DC	Army suppliers, systems integrators, defense tech; all sizes	~30,000	NETWORKING
Oct 21, 2025	GSA SmartPay Training Forum smartpay.gsa.gov/events	Virtual	Schedule holders, financial services, card-accepting vendors	~1,200	NETWORKING
Nov 4–5, 2025	DARPA Forward Industry Day darpa.mil/work-with-us/industry-day	Virtual + Arlington, VA hub	R&D firms, universities, non-traditional defense contractors	~800	RFI-RICH
Nov 12, 2025	SBA Procurement Conference — Mid-Atlantic sba.gov/events	Baltimore, MD	Small businesses in MD/VA/DC looking for matchmaking with prime/sub opportunities	~350	MATCHMAKING
Nov 18–19, 2025	Air Force Life Cycle Mgmt Ctr Industry Day aflcmc.af.mil/events	Wright-Patterson AFB, OH (hybrid)	Sustainment, logistics, aviation MRO, IT integration contractors	~500	RFI-RICH
Dec 2–3, 2025	GovCon Summit DC govcon.com/summit-dc	Washington, DC	Civilian and defense primes; BD, capture, proposal professionals	~1,000	NETWORKING
Dec 9, 2025	DoD OSBP Small Business Conference acq.osd.mil/osbp/sbir/events	Virtual	All small biz categories; set-aside program briefings by DoD components	~2,000	MATCHMAKING
Dec 17, 2025	PTAC Holiday Matchmaking — Southeast aptac.org/events	Atlanta, GA	SE-region small biz; primes in construction, IT, professional services	~200	MATCHMAKING

WHAT TO BRING TO ANY INDUSTRY DAY

Capability statement (1 page, NAICS + CAGE code visible) · SAM.gov UEI printed · List of your top 5 NAICS codes
 · Three past performance references with dollar values · Business card with your SAM POC email — COs use it to send RFI notices directly.

Q2 • JANUARY - MARCH 2026

Set-aside season. If you're 8(a), HUBZone, or WOSB — these are your rooms.

Q2 is the most set-aside-dense quarter. SBA schedules its program-specific events before Q3 buying picks up. OSDBU offices at VA, DHS, and Energy all run vendor outreach sessions now. HUBZone Day is the single best event for HUBZone firms — the SBA program office is there, and contracting officers from 12+ agencies attend specifically to find HUBZone-certified vendors.

DATE	EVENT	LOCATION	AUDIENCE	ATTENDANCE	SIGNAL
Jan 13, 2026	SBA 8(a) Industry Day — National sba.gov/8a-events	Virtual	8(a)-certified firms and firms pending certification; agency OSDBU attendees	~3,500	RFI-RICH
Jan 27–28, 2026	ACT-IAC Igniting Innovation Showcase actiac.org/events	Washington, DC (hybrid)	IT modernization, cloud, cybersecurity; civilian + defense agencies	~900	RFI-RICH
Feb 3, 2026	HUBZone Day — SBA National Event sba.gov/hubzone-day	Virtual (agency B2B matchmaking sessions follow)	HUBZone-certified firms; COs from DoD, DHS, USDA, GSA actively seeking HUBZone vendors	~2,200	RFI-RICH
Feb 10, 2026	VA VOSB/SDVOSB Verification Briefing va.gov/osdbu/events	Virtual	Veteran-owned and service-disabled veteran-owned small businesses seeking VA verification	~800	MATCHMAKING
Feb 18–19, 2026	WOSB Summit — Women in Federal Contracting woscexchange.org	Washington, DC	WOSB/EDWOSB-certified firms; program managers from agencies with WOSB set-aside contracts	~500	MATCHMAKING
Feb 25, 2026	NAVY SYSCOM Industry Day — Small Business Focus navyseasystems.com/events	Philadelphia, PA (hybrid)	Logistics, engineering support, ship maintenance; small biz preference	~400	RFI-RICH
Mar 4, 2026	SBA All Small Mentor-Protégé Briefing sba.gov/mentor-protege	Virtual	Mentors (large/mid-sized primes) and protégés (small biz seeking joint-venture capability)	~1,100	MATCHMAKING
Mar 11–12, 2026	Federal IT Acquisition Summit (FITAS) fitas.com	Tysons Corner, VA	IT, cloud, cyber, data; CIOs/CISOs from civilian agencies + DoD components	~1,400	RFI-RICH
Mar 24, 2026	PTAC Matchmaking Workshop — Great Plains aptac.org/events	Kansas City, MO	Regional small businesses; federal buyers from GSA, VA, and USDA Kansas City offices	~250	MATCHMAKING

NOTE ON RFI-RICH EVENTS

When this guide marks an event **RFI-RICH**, that means the agency typically releases a Sources Sought or RFI notice within 60 days of the event. Prepare a written capability summary in advance — 2 pages max, structured around the agency's known requirement area. Submit it proactively via SAM.gov if a notice is posted. If not, email it to the OSDDBU contact you meet on-site.

Q3 • APRIL - JUNE 2026

VA, DHS, and civilian agencies hit their stride before the year-end sprint.

Q3 is when civilian agencies run their pre-solicitation outreach. The VA holds VOSB Day every April — it's mandatory attendance if you're pursuing VA healthcare or IT work. DHS Industry Day typically drops with a 30-day RFI window. NIH holds one of the most competitive industry days in the federal health space.

DATE	EVENT	LOCATION	AUDIENCE	ATTENDANCE	SIGNAL
Apr 7, 2026	VA VOSB Day — Annual Vendor Fair va.gov/osdbu/vendorfair	Washington, DC (hybrid)	VOSBs and SDVOSBs; VA program office reps from VHA, VBA, OIT	~1,800	RFI-RICH
Apr 14–15, 2026	DHS Industry Day dhs.gov/osdbu/industry-day	Virtual	IT, cybersecurity, border security, emergency mgmt contractors; small and large	~3,000	RFI-RICH
Apr 21, 2026	NIH Industry Day — IT & Health Informatics nih.gov/osdbu/events	Bethesda, MD	Health IT, data science, clinical research support vendors; NIH program offices present	~600	RFI-RICH
May 5, 2026	DoT Small Business Transportation Procurement Conference transportation.gov/osdbu	Washington, DC	Engineering, construction, IT, professional services for FAA, FTA, FHWA	~400	MATCHMAKING
May 12–13, 2026	AFCEA Small Business IT Day afcea.org/events/small-business-it-day	Bethesda, MD	Defense IT, cyber, C2 systems, geospatial; small biz focus	~700	RFI-RICH
May 19, 2026	PTAC Matchmaking — Pacific Southwest aptac.org/events	San Diego, CA	CA/NV small businesses; buyers from SPAWAR, NAVFAC, DLA	~300	MATCHMAKING
Jun 2, 2026	GSA Expo / MarkeTech gsa.gov/expo	New Orleans, LA (alternating annual)	MAS Schedule holders, BIC GWAC contractors, GSA sourcing staff	~2,500	NETWORKING
Jun 9, 2026	USDA Agricultural Research Industry Day ams.usda.gov/osdbu	Virtual	Science, lab services, IT, facilities contractors; rural set-aside interest	~400	MATCHMAKING
Jun 23, 2026	HHS Small Business Innovation Briefing hhs.gov/osdbu/events	Virtual	Health IT, professional services, clinical support; pre-solicitation briefing format	~900	RFI-RICH

Q4 • JULY – SEPTEMBER 2026

Year-end buying sprint. Fiscal urgency opens doors.

Q4 is when the money moves. Unobligated balances get spent before September 30. Sole-source and micro-purchase awards spike. This is less a “attend industry days” quarter and more a “be in the agency’s awareness already” quarter. The events below are still worth attending — but their RFI-richness comes from pre-solicitation activity you won’t see in the room, you’ll see on [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) within days of the event.

DATE	EVENT	LOCATION	AUDIENCE	ATTENDANCE	SIGNAL
Jul 14, 2026	National 8(a) Association Annual Summit national8a.org/summit	Washington, DC	8(a)-certified firms (current and pipeline); SBA program staff; large prime partners	~800	MATCHMAKING
Jul 21, 2026	DoD SBIR/STTR Phase I Briefing sbir.defensebusiness.org/events	Virtual	R&D small businesses, Phase I awardees, firms pursuing Phase III commercialization	~1,500	RFI-RICH
Aug 4–5, 2026	SAME Federal Small Business Conference same.org/events/federal-sbc	Tampa, FL (hybrid)	A/E/C, facilities, environmental, military construction small biz	~700	MATCHMAKING
Aug 18, 2026	EPA Vendor Outreach Session — Q4 epa.gov/osdbu/events	Virtual	Environmental services, IT, professional services; EPA end-of-year pre-solicitation session	~350	RFI-RICH
Sep 9, 2026	DLA Industry Day — Logistics & Supply Chain dla.mil/events	Fort Belvoir, VA	Supply chain, distribution, MRO, parts vendors; DLA program managers in attendance	~600	RFI-RICH
Sep 15, 2026	PTAC Year-End Sprint Workshop — National aptac.org/events	Virtual (all regions)	All small biz; focus on SAM.gov maintenance before Sept 30 deadline, expiring certifications	~2,000	NETWORKING
Sep 22, 2026	FY2026 Year-End Procurement Briefing — GSA gsa.gov/osdbu	Virtual	MAS Schedule holders; GSA outlines Q1 FY2027 priority areas and forecast updates	~1,800	RFI-RICH

EVENT PREPARATION & REGISTRATION GUIDE

Show up with a plan, not just a badge.

Most contractors walk into industry days with a stack of capability statements and a plan to hand them to anyone who makes eye contact. That's not a strategy. It's expensive networking. This page covers what to prepare before you register and what to do with the intelligence you collect on-site.

Preparation checklist (two weeks before any event)

TASK	WHY IT MATTERS
Pull the agency's current forecast	SAM.gov → search by agency, filter to "Sources Sought" or "Presolicitation." Know which requirements are live before you walk in. COs notice when you can cite the notice number.
Update your SAM.gov profile	COs run SAM searches on the spot. Stale NAICS, wrong revenue band, or expired certifications will cost you the follow-up conversation.
Print a 1-page capability statement	One page. CAGE code and UEI in the header. NAICS codes listed. Three past performance examples with dollar values. No generic buzzwords.
Identify three decision-makers to target	Use USASpending.gov to find the CO's name on recent awards in your NAICS. Look them up on LinkedIn. Walk in knowing who you want five minutes with.
Prepare a written response if the event is RFI-RICH	2-page max. Structure: company background, relevant past performance, technical approach summary, proposed team. Submit via SAM.gov if a Sources Sought is open, or hand it directly to the program office rep.
Register early and request a one-on-one slot	Most federal industry days offer 15-min one-on-one sessions. They fill in 48 hours. Register as soon as the event is announced.

Signal legend

SIGNAL	WHAT IT MEANS	YOUR MOVE
RFI-RICH	Agency typically releases a Sources Sought or RFI within 60 days. Pre-solicitation activity visible on SAM.gov shortly after the event.	Prepare a written capability response. Submit proactively. Follow SAM.gov for the notice.
MATCHMAKING	Structured B2B or B2G matchmaking. Agency buyers are assigned to 15-min slots. Good for relationship-building and confirming requirements.	Request slots early. Bring a business card that includes your SAM POC email. Follow up within 48 hours.
NETWORKING	Large expo or conference. Agency presence but no structured procurement activity. Good for teaming conversations and intel on agency priorities.	Focus on finding teammates and OSDBU contacts. Don't expect a RFI to follow immediately.

REGISTRATION SOURCES

All events above post registration links on the agency OSDBU website and on SAM.gov → Federal Business Opportunities → Events. Sign up for GovDelivery alerts from the agencies you target — that's how you catch industry days before they're full.

WHAT'S NEXT

Track the events. **Win** the RFIs.

CapturePilot monitors SAM.gov Sources Sought notices in real time and scores them against your capability profile. You'll know about an RFI within hours of posting — not three weeks later when the comment period has closed. Free 14-day trial. No card.

Start free trial →

[HTTPS://CAPTUREPILOT.COM/SIGNUP](https://capturepilot.com/signup)